

Case Marking and Category Flagging: Evidence from Slavic

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ABSTRACT:

Grammatical case is sometimes viewed as dispensable in linguistic theory. The most detailed attempt at relegating case from grammar is that of Pesetsky 2013, where case marking is argued to be category flagging; for example, the accusative on a noun is taken to be the result of a verb flagging the noun with category V. This paper demonstrates that category flagging is real, but distinct from case marking. The main phenomenon under examination is category flagging by Slavic prepositions, where P-flagging is demonstrably dissociated from case marking. Other possible instances of category flagging include N- and V-flagging in languages such as Shipibo, and Numeral flagging in Slavic and Iranian languages.

KEYWORDS:

grammatical case, grammatical category, prepositions, thematic cases, Polish

1 Introduction

Grammatical case is occasionally argued to be reducible to other linguistic primitives.¹ Early attempts at reducing case to meaning (Jakobson 1971a,b) are generally considered unsuccessful (see, e.g., Neidle 1988 and Franks 1995 for critiques), but other attempts at reducing case to independently needed notions followed, including the very recent proposal in Clem and Deal 2026 to reduce cases to configurations of ϕ features.²

Pesetsky 2013 is the most prominent and worked-out such reductionist attempt. On that approach, overviewed in more detail in section 3, the very notion of grammatical case is reduced to the notion of grammatical category; the key idea is that different cases are the result of flagging by different grammatical categories.³ For example, accusative is V(erb)-flagging and oblique/thematic cases are all instances of P(reposition)-flagging.

Interestingly, this proposal to reduce cases to categories has never been critically evaluated, and my aim is to do exactly that. The conclusion of this paper is that category flagging is real (as assumed in Pesetsky 2013), but distinct from case marking (contrary to Pesetsky 2013). In section 2, I introduce a conspicuous instance of category flagging in Slavic, namely, special post-prepositional forms of 3rd person pronouns, called @P forms below, and argue that the existence of this phenomenon is a problem for the frequently assumed position that thematic cases are always assigned by prepositions. In section 3, I argue that it creates even bigger problems for the “cases = categories” approach of Pesetsky 2013, which both overgenerates and undergenerates: not all hypothetically P-flagged pronouns in oblique/thematic cases are expounded as @P forms (section 3.1), while some hypothetically non-P-flagged pronouns in direct cases are expounded as @P forms (section 3.2). Hence, regardless of other – equally or even more serious – problems (section 3.3), the “cases = categories” analysis of Pesetsky 2013 cannot be maintained. Nevertheless, the mechanism of category flagging that this analysis assumes may be observed in various languages, not only Slavic, as pointed out in section 4, followed by the concluding section 5.

2 Thematic Cases Are Not Always Prepositional

The crucial phenomenon is illustrated with Polish examples (1a–b), involving genitive forms of 3rd person personal pronouns, and (2a–b), with dative forms.⁴ In (1a)–(2a), pronouns occur adverbially and only their usual *j-/i-* forms are acceptable. In (1b)–(2b), they occur post-prepositionally and only what I will call “@P forms”,⁵ starting with *n-*, are licit.⁶

- (1) a. Oczekuję {jej/jego / ich / *niej/*niego / *nich}. (POL)
 await.1SG 3SG.F/M.GEN 3PL.GEN 3SG.F/M.GEN.@P 3PL.GEN.@P
 ‘I am expecting/awaiting {her / him / them}.’

- b. Idę do {niej/niego / nich / *jej/*jego / *ich}. (POL)
 go.1SG to.P 3SG.F/M.GEN.@P 3PL.GEN.@P 3SG.F/M.GEN 3PL.GEN
 ‘I am going to {her / him / them}.’
- (2) a. Pomagam {jej/jemu / im / *niej/*niemu / *nim}. (POL)
 help.1SG 3SG.F/M.DAT 3PL.DAT 3SG.F/M.DAT.@P 3PL.DAT.@P
 ‘I am helping {her / him / them}.’
- b. Idę ku {niej/niemu / nim / *jej/*jemu / *im}. (POL)
 go.1SG towards.P 3SG.F/M.DAT.@P 3PL.DAT.@P 3SG.F/M.DAT 3PL.DAT
 ‘I am going towards {her / him / them}.’

Slavic @P forms of pronouns evolved from their interaction with three Proto-Slavic prepositions: *νῑn* ‘in(to)’, *sῑn* ‘with’, and *kῑn* ‘towards’.⁷ The final nasal *-n* was pronounced only when the preposition was followed by a vowel or glide. Given that this condition was typically satisfied by 3rd person personal pronouns, *-n* was reanalyzed as an *n*- part of such pronouns and spread to pronominal forms occurring after other prepositions. All Slavic languages seem to have made this distinction at one point, although it is now lost in South Slavic languages, which have settled on *n*- forms in all contexts, and in Belarusian, which has settled on *j*-/i/- forms.⁸ In most of the other Slavic languages, the distinction is present in ACC, GEN, DAT, and INS, but not in locative, which is a solely adpositional case, and not in nominative, which is usually assumed to never be adpositional (but see below).

Table 1 presents forms of 3rd person pronouns in Polish.⁹ Given that Polish has some prepositions combining with NOM (e.g., *via* ‘via, through’, exemplified in (14) in section 3.2), the table contains a separate NOM @P row (equal to NOM). Moreover, Polish seems to be exceptional among those Slavic languages that have distinct @P forms in *not* preserving this distinction in INS.

Case	singular			plural	
	M	N	F	+virile	–virile
NOM	on	ono	ona	oni	one
NOM @P	on	ono	ona	oni	one
ACC	jego	je	ją	ich	je
ACC @P	niego	nie	nią	nich	nie
GEN	jego	jego	jej	ich	ich
GEN @P	niego	niego	niej	nich	nich
DAT	jemu	jemu	jej	im	im
DAT @P	niemu	niemu	niej	nim	nim
LOC	—	—	—	—	—
LOC @P	nim	nim	niej	nich	nich
INS	nim	nim	nią	nimi	nimi
INS @P	nim	nim	nią	nimi	nimi

Table 1: Polish 3rd person personal pronouns (without weak forms)

Adjacency between Ps and pronouns was a crucial factor in the origin of @P forms, but it is not a *necessary* condition on the occurrence of @P forms in contemporary Polish;¹⁰ the attested (3)–(5) show that phonetic material may intervene between Ps and @P pronouns. In the case of (3) and (5), @P pronouns are second conjuncts in coordinate structures combining with Ps.¹¹ In (4), the intervening word is a so-called “incorporating” (Patejuk 2018) or “shifting” (Weisser 2024) conjunction, *zaś* ‘while, (contrastive) and’.¹²

(3) Jesteś wściekła na siebie i {niego / *jego}. (POL)

be.2SG mad.SG.F on.P self.ACC and 3SG.M.ACC.@P 3SG.M.ACC

‘You are mad at yourself and him.’

(4) Wokół zaś {nich / *ich} otwierał się widok. . . (POL)

around.P and 3PL.GEN.@P 3PL.GEN opened REFL view.NOM

‘And a view opened around them. . .’

(5) . . . dzięki rybie i {niemu / *jemu}. (POL)

thanks.P fish.DAT and 3SG.M.DAT.@P 3SG.M.DAT

‘. . . thanks to the fish and him.’

An attempt to replace @P forms with the usual forms in (3)–(5) (i.e., with *jego*, *ich*, and *jemu*, respectively) results in ungrammaticality.

Importantly, adjacency is also not a *sufficient* condition for an @P form to be licensed. In (6) below, the form of the genitive pronoun following *wokół* ‘around’ is *ich*, not *nich* (cf. (4) above), as this time the pronoun is not a direct complement of the preposition, but rather expresses the possessor *within* such a complement.

(6) Wokół {ich / *nich} stolika zrobiło się gwarno. (POL)

around.P 3PL.GEN 3PL.GEN.@P table.SG.GEN became REFL bustle

‘A commotion ensued around their table.’

Again, there is no choice: the @P form *nich* is not acceptable here.

In summary, whenever a 3rd person personal pronoun is a complement of a P assigning ACC, GEN, or DAT, it must be exponed as an @P form. Given no adjacency requirement, this is not a (morpho)phonological process, but rather a (morpho)syntactic phenomenon. It is immediately explained by assuming that prepositional probes flag their complements with their own categorial feature P. Such an analysis is defended at length in Philippova 2018, based on similar Russian data, and I adopt it for Polish.

Hence, Slavic @P forms strikingly confirm the basic assumption of the “cases = categories” approach, namely, that heads *may* flag their complements with their categorial

features. However, as we will see in the following section, this phenomenon also directly contradicts the central claim of this approach, namely, that cases invariably *are* categories. In the remainder of the current section, we will see that this phenomenon is also problematic for claims that thematic cases are always assigned by Ps (overt or covert).¹³

The argument is very simple: if, say, dative were always assigned by a P, then only @P forms of relevant pronouns should be observed in dative environments. But this prediction is immediately contradicted by data such as (2a), repeated below as (7).

- (7) Pomagam {jej/jemu / im / *niej/*niemu / *nim}. (POL)
 help.1SG 3SG.F/M.DAT 3PL.DAT 3SG.F/M.DAT.@P 3PL.DAT.@P
 ‘I am helping {her / him / them}.’

In (7), involving adverbial dative, the dative @P forms starting with *n-* are unacceptable, and the usual *j-/i-* forms must be used instead. This means that adverbial dative cannot be analyzed as assigned by a (covert) preposition, at least not without additional assumptions.¹⁴

One line of defense could be that @P forms only combine with *overt* prepositions. Specifically, the distinction would have to be made between prepositions which are *born overt* and those that are *born covert*, given that elided prepositions still require @P forms, as in (8).¹⁵

- (8) Przecież to świadczy raczej przeciwko Tobie niż (przeciwko) niej / *jej. (POL)
 but this certifies rather against.P 2SG.DAT than against 3SG.F.DAT.@P / 3SG.F.DAT
 ‘After all, this speaks more against you than (against) her.’

Technically, such an analysis is easy to implement, but it would be highly unmotivated, as other processes of this kind do not seem to distinguish between overt and covert probes. In particular, on the frequently adopted analysis of Pesetsky and Torrego 2001,

covert T heads may flag DPs with their categorial features, so it is not clear why in Slavic only *overt* P heads should have this property.¹⁶ Moreover, this line of defense would also contradict the analysis of Russian @P forms in Philippova 2018, which argues for the presence of *covert* P-flagging prepositions in certain comparative constructions.

In summary, although the idea that thematic cases are always assigned by prepositions could be technically preserved by postulating syntactic differences between Ps born overt and those born covert, such syntactic differences are not independently motivated. Hence, the phenomenon of pronominal @P forms provides a conceptual – even if not technical – argument against analyzing thematic cases as always assigned by prepositions.

As we will see in the following section, the same data provide not only conceptual, but also technical arguments against the “cases = categories” approach.

3 Cases Are Not Categories

The idea that case assignment is simply category flagging is most comprehensively developed in Pesetsky 2013.¹⁷ According to that proposal, being nominative is tantamount to bearing the categorial D feature, accusative is V, genitive is N, and thematic cases are P.¹⁸ One way to bear such a feature is via lexical specification; for example, determiners are marked D in the lexicon, that is, they are born nominative, while nouns are lexically N, that is, born genitive. However, a head also flags its complements – and all accessible (i.e., not already spelled-out) lexical items within these complements – with its category.¹⁹ For example, when a verb merges with the direct object, V is added to the stack of categories already borne by lexical items within that object, for example D and N. As only the “outermost” category gets realized as a specific case,²⁰ words within that object are realized as V = ACC, instead of the original D = NOM or N = GEN.

3.1 Thematic Cases

The first major problem with this approach is a sharper version of the problem discussed in the previous section. The assumption that thematic cases *are* the P feature entails that all forms traditionally analyzed as, say, dative bear the P feature; in particular, all dative personal pronouns should bear P. But given the robust observation that P on 3rd person personal pronouns in languages such as Polish results in special @P forms, this analysis predicts that all dative 3rd person personal pronouns should be realized as @P forms. Again, this prediction is directly contradicted by data such as (9) (repeated again from (2a)).

- (9) Pomagam {je/*jemu* /im /**nej*/**niemu* /**nim*}. (POL)
 help.1SG 3SG.F/M.DAT 3PL.DAT 3SG.F/M.DAT.@P 3PL.DAT.@P
 ‘I am helping {her / him / them}.’

This problem for the “cases = categories” approach is not constrained to dative. While pronominal forms do not distinguish between adprepositional and adverbial instrumental in Polish (recall table 1), they do so in other languages with separate @P forms, including Russian, as the following examples demonstrate:

- (10) Ja dorožu {ej / im /**nej* /**nim*}. (RUS)
 1SG.NOM value.SG 3SG.F/M.INS 3SG.F/M.INS.@P
 ‘I value {her / him}.’
- (11) Ja stoju pered {nej / nim /**ej* /**im*}. (RUS)
 1SG.NOM stand.SG before.P 3SG.F/M.INS.@P 3SG.F/M.INS
 ‘I am standing before {her / him}.’

As seen in (10), adverbial instrumental *cannot* be realized by @P forms, while (11) shows that adprepositional instrumental on 3rd person personal pronouns *must* be realized by

such @P forms. This again directly contradicts the claim that thematic cases, of which instrumental is a prototypical example, are P: if they were, @P forms – and only @P forms – should be acceptable in (10) as exponents of 3rd person personal pronouns, just as they are in (11).

Note that such data present a much more serious problem for the claim that thematic cases *are* P than they presented for the claim that thematic cases are *assigned by* P, discussed in the previous section. There, a conceptually unmotivated but technically valid response was available, namely, that overt Ps mark their complements with both P and case, while covert Ps only flag them with case. Such a response is unavailable in the “cases = categories” approach discussed here, as the central claim of this approach is that case cannot be dissociated from category: it cannot be claimed that covert prepositions flag complements with a thematic case but not with category P, because – on this approach – thematic case *is* category P.

3.2 *Adprepositional Genitive, Accusative, and Nominative*

Problems for the “cases = categories” approach do not end with thematic cases. Genitive, accusative, and nominative create further issues.

Since GEN, ACC, and NOM are assumed to be categories N, V, and D respectively, they should only occur on words marked as N, V, and D in the lexicon – and Pesetsky (2013) does argue that Ns are born genitive – and on words flagged N, V, and D by such lexical Ns, Vs, and Ds. This correctly predicts that complements of Ns are typically genitive and complements of Vs are often accusative. However, by the same token, complements of Ps should never be genitive, accusative, or nominative. But in Slavic they often are,²¹ as illustrated by (12) (repeated from (1b)) for GEN (see also (4)), by (13) for ACC (see also (3)), and by the attested (14) for NOM (from the National Corpus of Polish).

(12) Idę do {niej/niego / nich / *jej/*jego / *ich}. (POL)

go.1SG to.P 3SG.F/M.GEN.@P 3PL.GEN.@P 3SG.F/M.GEN 3PL.GEN

‘I am going to {her / him / them}.’

(13) Pytam o {nią/niego / nich / *ją/*jego / *ich}. (POL)

ask.1SG about.P 3SG.F/M.ACC.@P 3PL.ACC.@P 3SG.F/M.ACC 3PL.ACC

‘I am asking about {her / him / them}.’

(14) ... a tymczasem słyszy od pani Rapaczyńskiej via ja, bo ja przekazałem,

and meanwhile hears from Ms. Rapaczyńska via.P I.NOM because I conveyed

że tego kompromisu nie ma. (POL)

that this compromise NEG have

‘... and meanwhile he hears from Ms. Rapaczyńska via me, because I conveyed that there is no compromise.’

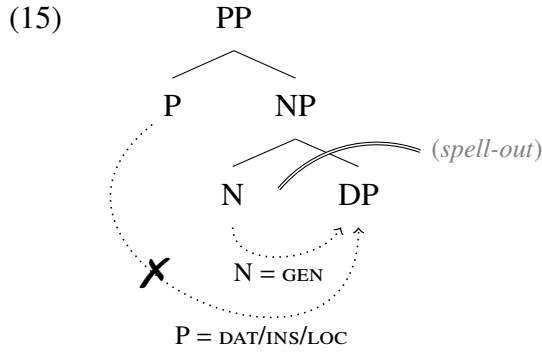
In order to maintain the “cases = categories” hypothesis, Pesetsky (2013) tentatively proposes that such apparent prepositions assigning GEN or ACC are in fact complex structures involving possibly empty Ns and necessarily empty Vs. (Prepositions combining with NOM are not considered in Pesetsky 2013.) Since rather different structures are proposed for the two cases, I will discuss them in separate subsections, starting with the genitive.

3.2.1 *Adprepositional Genitive*

In the case of Ps combining with GEN, Pesetsky 2013:sec. 8.5 notes that some such Russian Ps consist of what looks like a simpler P and what looks like an N. For example, the preposition *vmesto* ‘instead of’ may be decomposed into *v* ‘in(to)’ and *mesto* ‘place.ACC’.²²

Where such a decomposition is not morphologically motivated, a “null noun” is postulated. On this account, it is the overt or covert N that flags the DP complement with N = GEN. Given that DPs combining with Ns are phases (Pesetsky 2013:sec. 8.2–8.3), the

higher P cannot subsequently mark the DP with P = DAT/INS/LOC.²³ This is schematically illustrated in (15).



In view of the phenomenon discussed in previous sections, this analysis is untenable. In both Russian and Polish, adnominal 3rd person personal pronouns have the usual form, not the @P form, whether the noun combines with GEN, as in (16), or some thematic case, as in (17).

- (16) rozpad {jej/jego / ich / *niej/*niego / *nich} (POL)
 disintegration.N.NOM 3SG.F/M.GEN 3PL.GEN 3SG.F/M.GEN.@P 3PL.GEN.@P
 ‘disintegration of {her / him / them}’

- (17) pomoc {jej/jemu / im / *niej/*niemu / *nim} (POL)
 help.N.NOM 3SG.F/M.DAT 3PL.DAT 3SG.F/M.DAT.@P 3PL.DAT.@P
 ‘help for {her / him / them}’

And yet, as illustrated in (12) above, genitive complements of prepositions are realized as @P forms. This means that the source of adprepositional GEN is not an overt or covert N, but the P itself. This directly contradicts the idea that N = GEN and P = DAT/INS/LOC.

I do not see a way to save the “cases = categories” hypothesis from this problem. In particular, it will not do to say that the source of GEN is N, but somehow the higher preposition still flags the genitive pronoun with the P feature, resulting in an @P form. This is

not only because P is DAT/INS/LOC, so – given exponence assumptions in Pesetsky 2013 – flagging with P should result in one of these thematic cases, not GEN. It is also because complements of N are spelled-out right after they are flagged with N = GEN, as explicitly assumed in Pesetsky 2013 in order to account for the fact that complements of Ns cannot receive case from a higher head, so on this analysis they cannot interact with P in any way.

3.2.2 *Adprepositional Accusative*

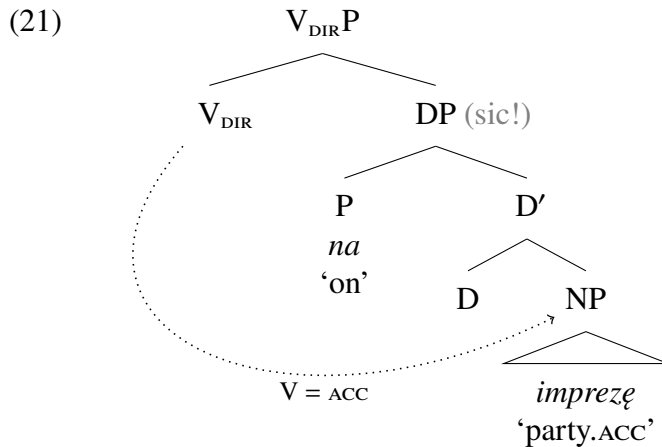
A similar problem for the “cases = categories” idea is caused by prepositions combining with ACC. As shown in (13) (and in table 1) above, such prepositions pattern with other prepositions in requiring @P forms of 3rd person personal pronouns. On the assumption in Pesetsky 2013 that V = ACC, the source of the accusative should be a V. However, Polish verbs cannot directly combine with @P forms, as illustrated in (18).

- (18) Widzę {ją / jego / ich / *nią / *niego / *nich}. (POL)
 see.1SG 3SG.F/M.ACC 3PL.ACC 3SG.F/M.ACC.@P 3PL.ACC.@P
 ‘I see {her / him / them}.’

The specific account of prepositions combining with ACC in Pesetsky 2013:sec. 7.3 is based on the observation that some such prepositions express direction and have homonyms which express location and assign a thematic case, as in (19)–(20).

- | | <i>Location</i> | <i>Direction</i> | |
|------|--|--|-------|
| (19) | a. Był na imprezie.
was.3SG.M on.P party.LOC
‘He was at a party.’ | b. Poszedł na imprezę.
went.3SG.M on.P party.ACC
‘He went to a party.’ | (POL) |
| (20) | a. Był za stodołą.
was.3SG.M behind.P barn.INS
‘He was behind the barn.’ | b. Poszedł za stodołę.
went.3SG.M behind.P barn.ACC
‘He went behind the barn.’ | (POL) |

Given the possible *semantic* decomposition of directional expressions such as *to a party* as [PATH TO [PLACE AT [THING PARTY]]] (cf. Jackendoff 1990:45), Pesetsky (2013) proposes to similarly *syntactically* decompose such directional prepositions as locative prepositions dominated by empty verbs expressing direction, see (21).²⁴



Such a nonstandard structure, with a nonprojecting P, is supposed to prevent the preposition from flagging the nominal with P = DAT/INS/LOC. This prevention is needed, because – unlike in the case of prepositions assigning GEN discussed in the previous subsection – there is no phase head here that could freeze the accusative NP *imprezε* ‘party.ACC’.²⁵ But if this structure prevents P from interacting with the nominal, 3rd person personal pronouns should occur in their usual form, not in @P form, contrary to facts.

In partial summary, the distribution of @P forms in Polish (and some other Slavic languages) provides multiple arguments against the “cases = categories” hypothesis of Pesetsky 2013. However, there are also other reasons to reject this reductionist approach.

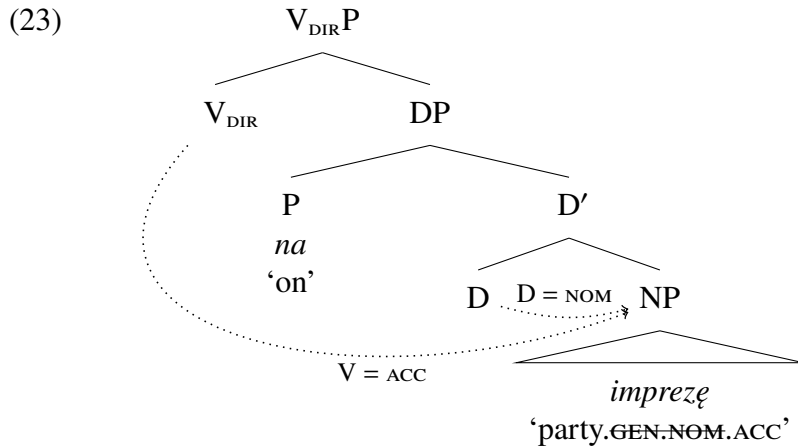
3.3 Other Problems

What gives the reductionist approach of Pesetsky (2013) much mileage is the idea of case stacking, based on earlier work by Richards (2013). While all nouns are born genitive (given that N = GEN), they are typically assigned the nominative case by D = NOM, which

is stacked on top of the “primeval genitive”. If no other flagging of this kind takes place, it is this outermost – nominative – case that is exponed according to the following “One-Suffix Rule” (Pesetsky 2013:11, ex. (7)):

(22) *The One-Suffix Rule*: Delete all but the outermost case suffix.

If, on the other hand, the resulting DP is a complement of another category, this category is added to the stack to be exponed instead of the “lower” N = GEN and D = NOM; and so on. Given such case stacking, the above tree (21) is just a schematic version of the more explicit (23).



In this structure, the noun eventually realized as the accusative form *impreze* is born genitive, as all Ns are. Then, it is marked by the null determiner as D, that is, nominative. Finally, assuming the impotency of the preposition *na* ‘on’ in this structure, it is marked by the null V_{DIR} as V, that is, accusative, and realized as such according to the One-Suffix Rule.²⁶

Nevertheless, even with case stacking and the One-Suffix Rule, a number of additional assumptions are needed to make the “cases = categories” idea initially viable, some of which are very nonstandard and not independently motivated. The following two subsections demonstrate that at least some of these additional assumptions are untenable –

independently of the phenomenon of @P forms.

3.3.1 *Adprepositional Accusative Is Not Assigned by V*

The first nonstandard assumption concerns the unusual structure of prepositions combining with ACC, shown in (23) above. There are good reasons to reject this analysis, regardless of the ad hoc nature of the structure in (23) (recall the nonprojecting P dominated by a DP) and – importantly – regardless of the distribution of pronominal @P forms.

Polish exhibits the phenomenon of Genitive of Negation (GoN), where – in the presence of sufficiently local verbal negation – the normally accusative complements are realized as genitive. Unlike in Russian, GoN in Polish is fully grammaticalized and obligatory, see (24)–(25).

(24) Klient nie chciał kupić {tej lampy / *tę lampę}. (POL)

client.SG.M.NOM NEG wanted.3SG.M buy.INF this lamp.SG.F.GEN/ACC

‘The customer didn’t want to buy this lamp.’

(25) Klient nie chciał, żeby kupić {tę lampę / *tej lampy}. (POL)

client.SG.M.NOM NEG wanted.3SG.M COMP buy.INF this lamp.SG.F.ACC/GEN

‘The customer didn’t want that this lamp be bought.’

In (24), while the higher (finite) verb is negated, it is the complement of the lower (infinitival) verb that is obligatorily realized as GEN instead of the usual ACC (cf. (18)).²⁷ This means that there is no boundary between the higher negated verb and the complement of the lower verb that would prevent the interaction that results in the genitive instead of the expected accusative. In particular, it cannot be the case that the DP object of the verb is spelled-out right after it merges with the verb and is flagged with V (as explicitly assumed in Pesetsky 2013:sec. 8.3), as then this DP would have to be spelled-out as accusative, regardless of the presence of higher negation. On the other hand, as shown in (25), GoN

does not happen across a CP projection, so CPs are such boundaries, in line with the usual assumption that CPs are phases.

Given these facts, Polish GoN provides the following argument against the structure in (23). If PPs involving accusative complements were actually VPs, then GoN should penetrate them and result in nominals within such PPs being realized as GEN. For example, the structure of (26) should be fully analogous to that of (24): the negation on the higher verb should trigger GEN on the complement of the lower verb (the hypothetical null V_{DIR} , in the case of (26)). But it does not: only the ACC form *imprezę* is acceptable in (26). Hence, the structure in (23) cannot be correct.

- (26) Nie poszedł na {imprezę/*imprezy}. (POL)
 NEG went.3SG.M on.P party.SG.ACC/GEN
 ‘He didn’t go to a party.’

If the reasoning above is on the right track, then also examples such as (27), where a PP containing an accusative phrase combines directly with a noun, are a problem for the “cases = categories” account in Pesetsky 2013.

- (27) alergia na {koty/*kotów} (POL)
 allergy.NOM on.P cats.PL.ACC/GEN
 ‘allergy to cats’

Assume again that PPs have the structure in (23) and that DPs are *not* spelled-out when they combine with Vs (as otherwise Genitive of Negation facts would be unexpected). Then, when such a PP combines with a noun, lexical items within this PP should be marked with N = GEN.²⁸ If so, the form of the noun should be *kotów* ‘cats.PL.GEN’, and not *koty* ‘cats.PL.ACC’ – contrary to facts.

In summary, the idea that adpositional ACC is actually assigned by a null V cannot

be maintained, regardless of the distribution of @P forms. At least some instances of ACC cannot be V, contrary to the “cases = categories” hypothesis.

3.3.2 *Vs Do Not Combine with Nominative Objects*

Another nonstandard assumption needed to maintain the “cases = categories” hypothesis is that Russian Vs idiosyncratically mark only some DP complements with V = ACC (those whose ACC morphology is different than NOM), but not others (those that would be traditionally analyzed as syncretic with NOM).

This assumption is needed to account for the structure of Russian numeral phrases; (28a–b) are based on Pesetsky 2013:51–52, (58)–(59).

- | | | | | | | | |
|------|----|--|---------------|----|----------------------------------|---------------|-------|
| (28) | a. | <i>pjat'</i> | <i>stolov</i> | b. | <i>pjati</i> | <i>stolam</i> | (RUS) |
| | | five.NOM=ACC | tables.PL.GEN | | five.DAT | tables.PL.DAT | |
| | | ‘five tables’ (in NOM and ACC positions) | | | ‘five tables’ (in DAT positions) | | |

In NOM and ACC positions, the noun within a numeral phrase must occur in GEN, while in other case positions, for example DAT, the numeral and the noun both occur in the expected case.

On the analysis of Pesetsky 2013, which is too complex to present here in detail, the GEN form of *stolov* ‘tables’ in (28a) is the “primeval genitive”. For theory-internal reasons, the null D, which would normally assign both the numeral and the noun the D = NOM case, fails to do so in the case of the noun, which – hence – stays in GEN. This accounts for (28a) in NOM positions. However, in ACC positions, the verb should mark its complement with V = ACC, resulting in the ungrammatical **pjat' stoly* ‘five.ACC tables.ACC’ instead of (28a).

In order to prevent this, Pesetsky (2013:66, (77)) posits a “Russian-specific restriction on assignment of [V = ACC]”, which says that V = ACC is assigned only to complements which are a) singular feminine, b) animate, or c) pronominal. Crucially, this list does not

include plural inanimate numeral phrases such as (28a). Hence, on this analysis, such numeral phrases in ACC positions are indeed NOM, rather than just syncretic with NOM.

Despite its ingenuity and complexity, this analysis cannot be maintained – not only because it lacks independent motivation. This is clear from coordination facts such as (29).

- (29) My smešali pjat' {ingredientov / *ingredienty} i {vodu / *voda}. (RUS)
 we.NOM mixed.PL five.ACC=NOM ingredients.PL.GEN/ACC=NOM and water.SG.ACC/NOM
 ‘We mixed five ingredients and water.’

The coordination in (29) must be understood collectively, that is, an elliptical (“conjunction reduction”) analysis is unavailable here. This means that the whole coordinate structure is a single complement of the verb *smešali* ‘mixed’. According to the analysis in Pesetsky 2013, the V must “decide” right after merge whether its complement should be assigned V = ACC, or not. If it decides to assign ACC, the form of the numeral phrase should be the unacceptable **pjat' ingredienty* ‘five.ACC ingredients.ACC’. If it decides not to assign ACC, the form of ‘water’ should be the nominative *voda*, completely unacceptable in (29).

This shows that the assumption that some adverbial complements stay in the nominative is empirically problematic. But without this assumption, the analysis makes wrong predictions about numeral phrases in accusative positions: nominals within them should be ACC, instead of the observed GEN. Hence, the analysis of Russian numerals in Pesetsky 2013, central to the development of the “cases = categories” approach, cannot be right.

In summary, not only does the distribution of Slavic @P forms provide rather direct arguments against any attempt to reduce cases to categories, but also various particular assumptions in Pesetsky 2013 needed for the initial viability of this hypothesis are untenable. Of course, this does not constitute an ultimate proof that the “cases = categories” hypothesis is false, but – given that Pesetsky 2013 is the only worked-out defense of this

hypothesis – this puts the burden of defending it squarely on the shoulders of its proponents.

4 Category Flagging Elsewhere

This paper started by providing an argument against the common Minimalist assumption that thematic cases are always assigned by prepositions, but the relevant phenomenon – distinct @P forms of 3rd person personal pronouns in Slavic – turned out to be especially problematic for the “cases = categories” reduction. Given that various aspects of the most comprehensive implementation of this reductionist program, that of Pesetsky 2013, are untenable also for other reasons, we concluded that cases cannot be reduced to categories.

However, Slavic @P forms also confirm an important assumption behind Pesetsky’s (2013) analysis, namely, that category flagging is real. This section suggests that category flagging may also be observed elsewhere and that it may sometimes be indeed confused with case marking.

Such a possible confusion concerning the ergative language Shipibo (Panoan, spoken in Peru) is in fact suggested by Baker (2015:20–21, 166–171). In this language, apart from the ergative (on subjects of transitive verbs) and absolutive (on other arguments of verbs), a separate adnominal “genitive” case may in principle be assumed. However, this genitive and ergative are morphologically distinguished only by two personal pronouns (1sg and 3sg), while being absolutely syncretic (Calabrese 2008) within lexical nouns. This is illustrated in (30) (Baker 2015:20, ex. (28); morphosyntactic information modified here): in (30a), ergative and genitive forms of a proper name are the same, while in (30b), ergative and genitive forms of a pronoun are different.

- (30) a. Jose-kan ochiti ben-ai. / Jose-kan ochiti (SHP)
Jose-ERG dog seek-IPFV / jose-GEN dog

‘José is looking for a/the dog.’ / ‘José’s dog’

b. E-n ochiti ben-ai. / nokon ochiti (SHP)

I-ERG dog seek-IPFV / my.GEN dog

‘I am looking for a/the dog.’ / ‘my dog’

On the basis of such data, Baker (2015) proposes to treat ergative and genitive in Shipibo and in some other languages with similar systematic ergative–genitive syncretism as a single case, with different forms of the exceptional items – such as the two pronouns in Shipibo – reflecting the difference between the nominal and clausal domain. This analysis may be directly translated to our terms: genitive and ergative in languages such as Shipibo are a single grammatical case, but relevant items are also flagged with categorial features of the higher head, and it is these different categorial features – nominal in the case of the apparent genitive and verbal in the case of the apparent ergative – that may lead to occasional differences in exponence as @N vs. @V forms, which in turn may cause the illusion of two separate grammatical cases. Note, however, that this reduction of two particular cases to a single case plus category flagging is not tantamount to relegating the notion of case from the grammar; in particular, Shipibo still distinguishes between ergative and absolutive.

One difference between Shipibo and Slavic is that, in Shipibo, different pronominal forms resulting from category flagging might be mistakenly – if Baker (2015) is right – taken as evidence for two different cases, while in Slavic, it is more difficult to make such a “mistake”, as @P forms occur in a number of traditional cases. Hence, treating them as separate cases would require postulating a separate “prepositional accusative”, in addition to the usual “nonprepositional accusative”, a separate “prepositional dative”, apart from the “nonprepositional dative”, and so on. However, interestingly, exactly this *has* been proposed at one point in Slavic literature, namely in Zaliznjak 1967 for Russian and, more

tentatively, in Saloni 1981 for Polish, where such an analysis is eventually rejected for the same reason that a separate Shipibo genitive is rejected in Baker 2015: because of the massive syncretism that such a multiplication of cases would engender.

In phenomena considered above – Slavic @P forms and Shipibo @N vs. @V forms – category flagging is only expounded on (some) pronouns, not on lexical nouns. However, this does not need to be the case. One possible instance of category flagging on lexical nouns is the “count form” in Bulgarian, a language which – unlike almost all other Slavic languages – has no nominal case system, with some case distinctions preserved only in pronouns. However, despite this lack of nominal case, masculine nouns have a distinct form that may only appear after numerals, as in *dva jezika* ‘two languages’, where the form *jezika* differs both from the singular *jezik* ‘language’ and the plural *jezici* ‘languages’. The exact distribution of such “count forms” is complex,²⁹ but it is not controversial that they may *only* appear adnumerally. Hence, even though “count forms” historically evolved from the now lost dual number, and are sometimes analyzed as expounding some additional number value beyond singular and plural, the most natural analysis is that such “count forms” simply expone the numeral category with which they are flagged, that is, that they are @NUM forms.

Numeral-flagging may also be observed in other Slavic languages, although there evidence for it is much more subtle. For example, in Russian, there is a special plural @NUM form of the noun *čelovek* ‘person.SG’, which in the plural is normally based on the suppletive root *ljud*’ (e.g., *ljudi* ‘people.PL.NOM’), but in adnumeral contexts, in NOM, ACC, and GEN positions, it reverts back to the singular root *čelovek* (e.g., *dva čeloveka* ‘two people’, *pjat’ čelovek* ‘five people’). Interestingly, such adnumeral forms may also be observed in some modern Iranian languages (Pashto, Parachi, and Ossetic), as well as – to a lesser extent – in Modern and especially Middle Welsh (see Roncero 2025:220–221, 228 and references therein), which further demonstrates that category flagging is not constrained

to Slavic.

In summary, while this phenomenon is relatively rare (perhaps because its functional usefulness is limited), different manifestations of category flagging may be observed in various languages. Apparently, this kind of flagging has not so far been considered in typological literature, which constrains flagging to case marking and adpositions, even though category flagging seems to be compatible with definitions of flags such as (31) (Haspelmath 2019:96, ex. (6), with an extension suggested in fn. 20 on p. 111).

(31) A *flag* is a bound form that occurs on a nominal and that indicates the semantic or syntactic role of the nominal with respect to:

- a. a verb (in a clause),
- b. a possessed noun (in a complex nominal),
- c. an adposition.

Some of the instances of category flagging mentioned above are already in the scope of this definition (Slavic @P forms – see (31c), Shipibo @N vs. @V forms – see (31a–b)), while others require extending the list of constructions in (31a–c) to numeral constructions (regular @NUM forms in Bulgarian and some Iranian languages, idiosyncratic @NUM forms in Russian).³⁰

5 Conclusion

The moral of this article is that the case for grammatical case as an independent theoretical primitive is as strong as ever. The single comprehensive attempt to reduce case to other syntactic primitives in Pesetsky 2013 is as unsuccessful as the earlier attempt to reduce it to semantic primitives in Jakobson 1971a,b. However, the mechanism of category flagging that this attempt makes conspicuous is real and, indeed, sometimes hard to distinguish from case marking, as in the case of the hypothetical genitive in Shipibo. Perhaps

some apparent grammatical cases in some languages may also be reduced to configurations of ϕ features, as recently proposed in Clem and Deal 2026. However, such possible reductions must be carefully investigated on a case-by-case basis, and they do not make it possible to eliminate the notion of grammatical case from linguistic theory.

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Notes

Initial versions of this paper were written when I was a visiting professor at MIT Linguistics in 2024–2025 and I am very grateful for the hospitality of everybody there. I am especially grateful to David Pesetsky, who was very generous with his time and wisdom – we spent long hours discussing issues related to this paper (me: “This argument is the final blow to your case theory”, David: “No, it’s just a scratch on the paint”) and many others. Also other people I interacted with at MIT and Harvard provided valuable comments on earlier versions of the material presented here, especially Jonathan Bobaljik, Norvin Richards, Oddur Snorrason, and Vlad Orlov, who also helped me with Russian data. Many thanks to Martin Haspelmath for comments on “category flagging” and for useful references. Closer to home, I benefited from comments from my colleagues at the Formal Linguistics Group of the Polish Academy of Sciences, Agnieszka Patejuk and Sebastian Zawada, as well as from the anonymous reviewers, who clearly engaged with the paper and provided multiple constructive suggestions. Finally, the whole process at *Linguistic Inquiry* has, as always, been exemplary, with Jay Keyser’s balanced decisions and clear recommendations, with Sheelah Ward’s unmatched communicative skills, and with Anne Mark’s meticulous copyediting.

¹The notion of grammatical case assumed here is what is sometimes called “morphological case”, that is, a grammatical feature with values traditionally called “nominative / absolutive”, “accusative”, “ergative”, “genitive”, “dative”, or “instrumental”. However, I use the term “grammatical case” – or “case” in short – instead of the potentially confusing “morphological case”, as I view case as a predominantly syntactic feature (similarly to the view in Pesetsky 2013). This notion should be distinguished from the related but more abstract notion of Case prominent in GB and early Minimalism (Vergnaud 2006, Chomsky 1980, 1981, 1995), whose current status is controversial. Such abstract “Case” is explicitly rejected in many De-

pendent Case approaches (e.g., in Marantz 1991, McFadden 2004, and Preminger 2014, 2024), and does not seem to play any role in others (e.g., Bobaljik 2008 and Baker 2015). It is also questioned in work beyond Dependent Case, with proposals to explain at least some of the DP-licensing effects of “Case” with other mechanisms (e.g., Pesetsky and Torrego 2004 and Richards 2010) and to replace “abstract Case” with a less confusing term such as “Vergnaud-licensing” (Pesetsky 2013).

²The semantic approach of Jakobson 1971a,b, on which cases were matrices of binary semantic features, was also followed by various more syntactic proposals to represent cases as matrices of distinctive features (see, e.g., Neidle 1988 and Franks 1995 again). However, as discussed in Pesetsky 2013:134, n. 3, such decomposition is not reduction, given that the assumed features are as *sui generis* as cases. (See also Caha 2009:sec. 1.2 on the limited predictive power of such binary decomposition.)

³The term “flagging”, corresponding to “Feature Assignment” in Pesetsky 2013, is used in this paper roughly in the sense of Clem and Deal 2026: in a probe–goal relation, the goal “values” certain features of the probe, while the probe “flags” the goal with certain features. This technical notion of flagging is related to the homonymous notion employed in typological literature (on which more in section 4 below).

⁴All examples are marked with ISO 639-3 codes (POL = Polish, RUS = Russian, SHP = Shipibo). Glosses follow the Leipzig Glossing Rules.

⁵Such forms are called “post-prepositional” in Polish linguistics, “prepositional” or “ad-prepositional” in some work on Russian, and “n-forms” in Philippova 2018.

⁶Grammaticality status of these and most of the other examples in this paper is uncontroversial, but it is always confirmed by a handful of native speakers. Where it might be less obvious, as in the case of examples (3)–(5) below, informal acceptability judgments are supported by attested examples from the National Corpus of Polish (<http://nkjp.pl/>; Przepiórkowski et al. 2012). While most of the arguments in sections 2–3 could be based on Russian, which

would be natural given that Pesetsky 2013 is mostly based on Russian data, this paper is mainly based on Polish – both for opportunistic reasons (better access to native speakers and linguistic resources) and on empirical grounds (more robust lack of adjacency requirement of @P forms with respect to the selecting Ps, see footnote 10, and more grammaticalized genitive of negation, see section 3.3.1).

⁷This paragraph is based on Philippova 2018:sec. 2.1; see Hill 1977 for more details.

⁸As noted by an anonymous reviewer, the South Slavic situation is more complex than usually summarized in the literature (and in the main text above): the distinction at hand has been lost in the case of strong pronominal forms, which are the basis of my argument, but it is preserved on weak pronominal forms, of which there are two series: non-*n*-clitics (e.g., *ga* ‘3SG.M.ACC’), which do *not* occur adprepositionally, and *n*-nontonic forms (e.g., *-nj* ‘3SG.M.ACC’), which *only* occur with (some) prepositions. See Stegovéc 2020, 2023 for full paradigms of Slovenian personal pronouns, as well as footnote 9 for some information on weak forms in Polish.

⁹Masculine singular non-adprepositional pronouns also have weak forms in ACC, GEN, and DAT, and similarly for neuter pronouns in GEN and DAT. In (1a)–(2a), only the strong forms *jego* and *jemu* are shown, even though they are less natural than the weak forms *go* and *mu* out of context, as they usually require some contrastive stress. These sentences would be fully natural if these pronouns were preceded by *tylko* ‘only’ or followed by *a nie jej* ‘and not her’. All other acceptable forms in these examples are fully natural regardless of stress, even though masculine singular @P forms also have a weak allomorph in ACC and GEN, namely, the suffix *-ń* (so the singular masculine version of (1b) could be expressed as *Idę doń*).

¹⁰As discussed in detail in Philippova 2018, there is still some variation regarding the sensitivity of Russian @P forms to whether they are adjacent to prepositions or not: in some contexts, they are obligatory when adjacent to a P (e.g., when they are first conjuncts in a nominal coordinate structure combining with the P), but optional when they are not (e.g., when they are second conjuncts), with some additional speaker variation.

¹¹The form *dzięki*, while homonymous with a nominal form meaning ‘thanks’, is a preposition in (5), as evidenced by its co-occurrence with @P forms.

¹²As noted by an anonymous reviewer, it might seem from these examples that nonadjacency of P and @P forms requires some kind of coordinate structure, but this is not the case, as illustrated by the following attested coordination-free example (from Przepiórkowski 2025:15, fn. 42, which see for discussion).

- (i) Do obu nich podbiega ewidentnie rozjuszony pies. . . (POL)
to both.GEN 3PL.GEN.@P run.up obviously angry.NOM dog.NOM
‘An obviously angry dog runs up to both of them. . . ’

¹³See Řezáč 2008 and much subsequent work.

¹⁴This problem is also mentioned in Baykov and Rudnev 2020:895–896, in the context of dative controllers in Russian.

¹⁵This attested example (from the National Corpus of Polish) occurs without the second *przeciwko* ‘against’, but – as indicated in (8) – it would also be acceptable with it.

¹⁶An anonymous reviewer mentions that eliding T seems to result in the accusative – instead of the expected nominative – on the pronominal subject in English, as in *We can’t eat caviar and him beans* (vs. . . . *and he can’t eat beans*) (Schütze 1997:54, ex. (65j)), but has- tens to add that, assuming Caha’s (2024) approach to default case, *him* may alternatively be analyzed as strong nominative here (cf. French *je* ‘I.NOM.DEFICIENT’ vs. *moi* ‘I.{NOM/ACC/DAT}.STRONG’), so even in this case it is not clear that overt and covert T have different flagging properties.

¹⁷A well-known forerunner of this analysis is the proposal in Pesetsky and Torrego 2001 that the abstract nominative Case is actually the category feature T on a DP constituent. However, this proposal reduces a particular Case value, but does not yet count as an attempt to get rid of the notion of abstract Case (never mind grammatical case) from the grammar.

¹⁸An immediate issue for this analysis, noted in Pesetsky 2013:7, is that this requires pro-

liferation of prepositional categories: P_{DAT} , P_{INS} , and so on. A radical solution would be to claim that each preposition is a separate category (see Merchant 2019 and Zyman 2024), but then many different such “prepositional categories” – for example, 11 Polish prepositions combining with DAT or 10 combining with INS (cf. footnote 21) – would have the same exponence on nominal constituents, leading to the extremely improbable exceptionless massive syncretisms in all languages with multiple prepositions assigning the same grammatical case.

¹⁹See, for example, the 4th version of the Feature Assignment principle in Pesetsky 2013:88, ex. (112). As to spell-out, there does not seem to be a single specific version of phase theory assumed in Pesetsky 2013, however DPs are explicitly assumed to be phases spelled-out immediately after they merge with a head and receive this head’s category (see sec. 8.2–8.3 there).

²⁰Pesetsky 2013:11, ex. (7), cited in section 3.3 below as (22).

²¹According to the electronic morphological dictionary PoliMorf (<https://zil.ipipan.waw.pl/PoliMorf>; Woliński et al. 2012), there are 71 different simple (one-word) prepositions combining with GEN , 22 with ACC , and 19 with NOM , compared to only 11 combining with DAT , 10 with INS , and 5 with LOC in Polish. Such prepositions are also textually frequent: in the 1-million-word balanced and manually-annotated subcorpus of the National Corpus of Polish, over half of prepositional tokens combine with GEN , ACC , or NOM (GEN : 27.9%, ACC : 21.5%, NOM : 0.8%; other frequencies: LOC : 37.6%, INS : 11.4%, DAT : 0.7%).

²²See the next subsection on a possible source of ACC on *mesto*.

²³If not for this phase effect, such case stacking would be possible, and the outermost case would be expounded instead.

²⁴Pesetsky (2013:148, n. 11) notes that for some ACC -assigning prepositions such an analysis is unmotivated, but leaves it “as an unsolved problem”.

²⁵Nor is such a phase possible in principle, given that the ACC -flagging V_{DIR} is above P .

²⁶On this approach, prepositions combining with NOM , such as *via* ‘via, through’ in (14) above, could be analyzed as having an impoverished structure: only DP , without the $V_{\text{DIR}}P$ layer. Then,

the outermost case suffix on the nominal complement would be $D = \text{NOM}$. However, given the inherent directionality of *via* and its synonymy with *przez* ‘through’, which does combine with ACC , it is counterintuitive to analyze *via* as lacking the directional $V_{\text{DIR}}P$ layer.

²⁷With growing distance between negation and the affected nominal, accusative becomes more acceptable (Przepiórkowski 2000), but it is not clear whether this is a grammatical fact or a performance effect. In the case of (24)–(25), acceptability differences between GEN and ACC are dramatic.

²⁸Even if Ns are assumed to be phase heads, so that the PP is spelled-out once it combines with the N, this spell-out happens only *after* the N category is transferred, as explicitly discussed in Pesetsky 2013:88, ex. (111), so the problem remains.

²⁹See for example Pancheva 2018, Franks 2018, and Ionin and Matushansky 2018:sec. 6.6.3, as well as Stateva and Stepanov 2016 for corpus-based arguments that some of this complexity is a matter of performance (“agreement errors”).

³⁰This list requires further extensions anyway, including to adjectives, which may assign specific cases in languages such as Polish, for example, *świadomy ryzyka* ‘aware (of) risk.GEN’ or *wierny zasadom* ‘faithful (to) principles.DAT’.